

VIOO Milestone 1: Requirements

Web-first app, mobile-friendly, built in a stack that can later wrap into iOS/Android containers.
Delivered at a URL.

Part 1: Risk assessment (read before specs)

Risk 1: The first-swipe problem

Politics is boring to most people. The MVP has one job on first load: make the visitor feel like they discovered something. If the home page feels like a directory, we've lost.

Primary mitigation: the poster cards. The emotional hook on first load is the visual itself. A scroll of bold, magazine-cover-quality candidate posters is genuinely different from any political tool or news aggregator. Build quality on these cards is a launch requirement, not polish for later. See Part 4.1.

Secondary mitigations baked into the requirements below: - Home feed leads with candidates who have fresh, newsworthy content this week (not alphabetical, not a directory) - Each card surfaces the single hottest topic on them right now as a one-line hook - First-time visitors see a mix of nationally recognized names and lesser-known candidates from flippable races, so there's both recognition and discovery

Risk 2: Scraper sufficiency

The app lives or dies by whether our free scrapers produce enough content per candidate to make profile pages feel alive.

What we know will work well: - **Federal candidates** (Senate, House, governors, major mayors) get dense daily news coverage and have active YouTube channels. Scrapers will give us plenty. -

Incumbents have RSS feeds, .gov pages, and press release output. Constant content stream.

What's weaker: - **Downballot candidates** (state legislators, local races) often have 2-5 news mentions per month and minimal video presence. Their pages will feel thin. - **First-time challengers** without campaign infrastructure produce little content themselves. - **Candidates who aren't on Bluesky** (most Republicans, many moderates) miss that entire channel.

Decision: The seeded 25 are picked partly based on scraper-friendliness. We prioritize races where coverage is dense. State legislators and local races wait for Milestone 2 when community submissions can fill the gap.

Pre-build action: Before writing any app code, we run a one-week scraper sanity check against a shortlist of 30 candidates. Count how many items per candidate per week the scrapers pull. If the

average is under 5 items per candidate per week, we have a real problem and need to rethink sources.

Risk 3: The empty-page scenario

Even with good scraper coverage, some candidate pages will be sparse for days or weeks. We need to handle this gracefully.

Mitigations: - Candidate pages with no recent content show "Latest this month" instead of "Latest this week" as a fallback window - If there's truly nothing within 30 days, the page shows the candidate's bio, official links, and a donate button, with a line like "No recent coverage. Subscribe to know when there is." - Subscription CTA is the escape hatch: the user doesn't walk away empty-handed even when the page is thin

Risk 4: Neutrality and trust

Users need to feel the platform isn't dictating who appears or what gets surfaced. If we look like a partisan directory, credibility dies.

Requirements: - Both parties represented in the seeded 25 from day one (even if your Instagram audience is overwhelmingly progressive, the app needs to show balance) - Candidate pages show the candidate's own content alongside third-party coverage, with clear source labels - No editorial ranking beyond "most recent" and "most engaged-with by scraper signals" - Submission forms (both candidate claim and future community submissions) are open to any verified party

Risk 5: The revenue pipe

Donate buttons have to convert, even without a community layer. Without comments or voting, emotional investment is low. Mitigations:

- Every topic card has a clear donate button, not just the top-level profile
- Donate buttons carry referral codes from day one so the Instagram-tested revenue path works in-app too
- The email digest includes donate links, which drives conversion in the inbox where the context is warmer

Risk 6: Staffer disinterest

The staffer flow only matters if staffers actually set up their candidates' pages. They won't do anything complicated. Requirements:

- Claim flow is under 5 clicks from form submission to approved
- Staffer dashboard has three things only: edit branding (colors, photo, tagline), add official account links for scraping, add donation link. Nothing else.
- After setup, zero ongoing maintenance required. Scrapers run automatically.

- Manual approval step (you) keeps quality high at low volume
-

Part 2: User personas

The Scroller (primary consumer). Saw a VIOO Instagram post, clicked the link, landed on the web app. Wants a quick orientation on who's running and what's happening. Won't sign up for anything unless there's immediate value. Success metric: subscribes to email or taps donate.

The Subscriber (returning consumer). Someone who subscribed to the daily or weekly digest. Receives the email, clicks through for deeper reads. Success metric: opens the email regularly, clicks through to the app, eventually donates.

The Staffer (candidate administrator). Works for a campaign. Heard about VIOO from a colleague or saw their candidate's page. Wants to claim the page with minimal effort. Success metric: completes setup in one sitting, never logs in again (unless they want to).

The Admin (you). Manages the platform. Approves staffer claims, seeds candidates, moderates edge cases. Success metric: less than 2 hours per week of admin work.

Part 3: Functional requirements

3.1 Home page (public, no login)

Purpose: Show the visitor in 15 seconds that there's something here worth engaging with. The poster cards are the emotional hook. They are not negotiable for launch.

Requirements: - Feed of **full poster-style candidate cards**, scrollable. These are the centerpiece of the product. - Each card is a campaign-poster-inspired design with: stylized candidate photo treatment, bold display typography for the name, campaign colors, office/district, party, and one-line hook (either a tagline or the headline of their hottest recent topic) - Cards use one of a small set of poster templates (2-3 at launch is enough, more can follow). Think: AOC-style two-tone, Zohran-style modernist split, Graham Platner-style high-contrast editorial. Each candidate is assigned a template that fits their brand. - Fewer candidates with full poster treatment beats more candidates with generic cards. Quality bar over quantity. - Cards are ordered by a freshness + recency signal (candidates with new content in last 48 hours surface first) - Small filter chip row at top: "All," "Senate," "House," "Governor," "Mayor," "State" (where applicable) - Persistent subscribe CTA at the bottom or as a sticky element: "Get the daily. One email, five races." - Tapping a card opens the candidate profile

3.2 Candidate profile (public, no login)

Purpose: The destination. Show everything about this candidate that a curious voter might want to know, organized by topic so it's scannable rather than a chronological firehose.

Requirements: - Billboard (top section): - Poster-style hero expanded from the home card (same design language, bigger canvas) - Name, office, party, location displayed prominently - Links: official website, donation page (primary CTA button), official social accounts (small icons) - Subscribe button specific to this candidate (for their personal digest, separate from global subscribe) - **Topic feed (below billboard):** - Content is **grouped into topic clusters**, not shown as a raw chronological list. This is the core organizing principle of the profile. A profile without topic clustering is a feed reader; a profile with topic clustering is a product. - Each topic card shows: - Topic name (AI-generated headline like "AOC pushes federal childcare guarantees") - Hero image pulled from the most compelling source in the cluster - AI-written one-line summary of what the cluster is about - Count of underlying sources ("12 articles, 3 videos") - Date range the cluster covers - Topics are ordered by recency + activity (hottest topic in the last 7 days surfaces first) - Tapping a topic card opens the topic detail view with the full source list - **Topic filter chips above the feed:** "All," "This week," plus dynamic chips based on active topics for this candidate (e.g., "Housing," "Gaza," "Taxes") - **Empty state handling:** - If no content in last 7 days: show "Latest this month" - If no content in last 30 days: show "No recent coverage. Subscribe to know when there is."

3.3 Topic detail view (public, no login)

Purpose: Let the user dig into every source behind a topic cluster. This is where the depth is.

Requirements: - Topic title at top - AI-written summary (2-3 sentences max, giving the user the gist before they commit to reading sources) - Date range the cluster covers - **Full list of underlying source items**, each with: - Thumbnail or source platform icon (news logo, YouTube play button, Bluesky icon, etc.) - Headline or excerpt - Source name and publication date - Source type label ("Article," "Video," "Post," "Press Release") - Tap to open source in new tab (we don't rehost content) - Sources grouped or sortable by type (articles, videos, posts) or date - Donate button at the bottom and floating/sticky on scroll - Related topics chip row at bottom (other topics on this same candidate, and the same topic on opposing candidates if applicable)

3.4 Email subscription flow (public, no login)

Purpose: Capture interested visitors without requiring full account creation. This is the signal feature.

Requirements: - **Global subscribe:** - Email input - Cadence selection: daily or weekly (only two options for simplicity) - Optional: "Focus on a party or region" with simple multi-select (Democrats, Republicans, Independents, plus state filter) - Submit → confirmation email → verified → subscribed - **Candidate-specific subscribe:** - Available on each candidate profile - Same email + cadence flow - User can subscribe to multiple candidates without creating an account; each email is tied to subscriptions via token link - **Subscription management:** - Every email has "manage preferences" and "unsubscribe" links - Preferences page (accessible by email token, no login): view subscriptions, change cadence, unsubscribe from individual candidates or all - **Email content:** - Daily: top 3-5 topic cards across subscribed candidates, with headlines, summaries, and donate buttons - Weekly: same

but larger roundup with 10 topics - Subject line is the biggest story of the day/week across subscribed candidates

3.5 Candidate submission form (public, no login required)

Purpose: Anyone can submit a candidate to be added to the platform. Manual approval by admin keeps quality high.

Requirements: - Public-facing form at a URL like `/submit-candidate` - Fields: - Candidate full name (required) - Office sought (required, dropdown: Senate, House, Governor, Mayor, State Legislature, Other) - State (required) - District (optional, for House/state races) - Party (required) - Official website URL (optional) - Official social accounts (optional, one field per platform: YouTube, Bluesky, Substack, campaign blog RSS) - Submitter's name and email (optional, for follow-up) - Submitter's reason ("why this candidate?" text field, optional) - Submit → confirmation page → admin reviews

3.6 Staffer claim flow (public, minimal login)

Purpose: Let campaign staff claim their candidate's page and customize it. Must be under 5 clicks to completion. Manual approval.

Requirements: - Public-facing form at `/claim-candidate` - Fields: - Candidate being claimed (search/select from existing candidate database) - Staffer name and email (required) - Staffer role (e.g., "Communications Director") - Proof of affiliation: link to a post on the candidate's verified account confirming the staffer's role, OR a contact form where we reach out to verify - Submit → confirmation → admin reviews → if approved, staffer gets an email with a magic-link login - **Once logged in, the staffer dashboard has three sections only:** 1. **Branding:** upload photo, set two campaign colors, set tagline 2. **Content sources:** add/edit URLs for YouTube channel, Bluesky handle, Substack, RSS feed, campaign blog. Each URL is validated by attempting a fetch. 3. **Donation link:** paste ActBlue/WinRed/campaign donation URL - **What staffers cannot do** (explicit, to match Zone 1/Zone 2 split from original spec): - Edit, hide, or remove scraped content - Change the topic clustering - See user identities or subscription lists - Alter donation counts or referral stats - **Post-setup experience:** zero maintenance required. Scrapers run automatically from the provided sources. Staffer is free to never log in again.

3.7 Admin dashboard (you, password-protected)

Purpose: You manage the platform here. Keep it simple because the whole point is minimal admin overhead.

Requirements: - Login (simple email + password, or magic link) - **Queue views:** - Pending candidate submissions (approve, reject with reason, or request more info) - Pending staffer claims (approve, reject with reason) - Scraper errors (candidates whose feeds are failing) - **Candidate manager:** - List of all candidates, filterable by party, state, active/inactive - Manually create, edit, or deactivate a candidate - For each candidate: view scraper status, last successful fetch time, number

of items pulled in last 7 days - **Subscription stats:** - Total subscribers - New subscribers this week - Cadence breakdown (daily vs. weekly) - **No moderation tools yet.** That comes with Milestone 2 when users can post.

3.8 Content ingestion pipeline (backend, invisible to users)

Purpose: The engine that keeps candidate pages alive. Runs automatically.

Requirements: - **Per candidate, scrape:** - Google News for articles mentioning the candidate's name (filtered by recency) - YouTube Data API for their official channel uploads - Bluesky public API for their posts (if handle provided) - RSS feeds from campaign site, Substack, .gov page (if provided) - **Deduplication:** the same URL should never appear twice. If the same article is pulled from News and also shared by the candidate on Bluesky, it's one item with both source tags. - **Frequency:** every 4 hours, staggered to avoid rate limits - **Topic clustering:** - Runs after ingestion - Groups items into topics using Claude Haiku via Batch API - Each topic gets an AI-generated headline and 2-3 sentence summary - Re-clusters as new items arrive, but caches aggressively - **Error handling:** if a source fails 3 times in a row, flag it in the admin dashboard; don't keep retrying forever

3.9 Donation flow (public, no login)

Purpose: Convert interest into dollars via referral links. Works without any user account.

Requirements: - Every candidate profile has a prominent "Donate" button in the Billboard - Every topic card has a smaller "Donate" button - Tapping Donate opens a bottom sheet (mobile) or modal (desktop) with: - Candidate photo and name - Office and district - One-line context ("1.2K people donated after seeing this" if we have that data later; skip for MVP) - Big CTA: "Donate now" → opens candidate's donation URL with our referral code appended, in a new tab - Referral codes are already provided by the organizations that pay per donation driven. Just append to URL. No custom tracking infrastructure needed. - **Optional enhancement for Milestone 1:** a "Share this candidate" button that copies a preformatted message to clipboard for pasting into iMessage, DMs, etc. Low effort, high upside.

Part 4: Design requirements

4.1 Visual system (the non-negotiable part)

The poster cards ARE the product on first impression. They're the reason anyone will want to open this versus reading the New York Times. Design effort and build time should reflect this.

- **Poster aesthetic** matches the original VIOO mockups: bold campaign-poster layouts for candidate cards, driven by each candidate's chosen colors and photo treatment. See reference: AOC's "¡OCASIO! CORTEZ" yellow poster, Zohran Mamdani's blue-and-orange "VOTED IN" card, Graham Platner's "UN-SHUCK THE SYSTEM" two-tone.

- **2-3 poster templates at launch.** Each template is a distinct layout: (1) a bold two-tone editorial style, (2) a modernist geometric split, (3) a high-contrast photographic cutout. Each seeded candidate is assigned the template that best matches their brand.
- **Typography:** one display face for candidate names (bold, editorial, poster-grade). One body face for everything else (clean, readable). The candidate name is a design element, not just a label.
- **Color system:** a neutral UI chrome (off-white background, dark text) so candidate brand colors pop when they appear.
- **Photo treatment:** stylized editorial treatment on candidate photos (two-tone, high contrast, halftone, or similar) to give the app a distinct look and keep us on solid legal ground for photo use. This is design work I (the founder) will handle per candidate during seeding.

Scope implication: building three solid poster templates takes real design time. If we have to cut somewhere, cut candidate count (start with 15 instead of 25) before cutting card quality. A visually striking app with 15 candidates beats a generic-looking app with 25.

4.2 Layout

- **Mobile-first.** Most traffic comes from Instagram, which means phones. Design for iPhone Safari first, scale up to desktop.
- **Desktop experience:** center column of ~520px on desktop, with possible side navigation later. Don't sprawl into multi-column feeds on large screens; it feels wrong for this content.
- **Tab bar on mobile:** Home, Subscribe, Submit, About. Four items max.
- **Desktop nav:** horizontal bar with same four items, logo left, subscribe CTA right.

4.3 Specific pages to design

- Home feed with poster cards
- Candidate profile (Billboard + topic feed)
- Topic detail view
- Email subscribe modal
- Candidate submission form
- Staffer claim form
- Staffer dashboard (three-section layout)
- Admin dashboard
- Empty states: sparse profile, no results, pending approval, subscribe success
- Email template: daily and weekly digest formats

4.4 Accessibility

- All interactive elements keyboard-navigable

- Color contrast meets WCAG AA for body text (this matters because candidate colors vary wildly; the UI shouldn't inherit unreadable color combos)
 - Alt text on candidate photos and scraped images
-

Part 5: Non-functional requirements

- **Performance:** home feed loads in under 2 seconds on 4G mobile
 - **Scale:** designed to handle 25 candidates and a few thousand subscribers at launch; scales to 200 candidates and 50k subscribers without rearchitecture
 - **SEO:** candidate pages have proper meta tags and Open Graph cards so shared links unfurl correctly on iMessage, X, and WhatsApp
 - **Security:** email tokens for subscription management are unguessable and time-limited. Admin dashboard requires real password. Staffer dashboard accessible only via magic link to approved email.
 - **Legal:** ToS includes "editorial coverage of public figures in their official capacity" language. Privacy policy covers email storage. FEC disclaimer where required.
-

Part 6: Pre-build validation (do this first)

Before writing app code, we run two tests:

1. **Scraper sanity check** (4-6 hours of engineering time): for 30 potential candidates, run the scrapers manually and count items per candidate per week across News, YouTube, RSS, and Bluesky. If the average is under 5 items per candidate per week, we need more sources or a smaller scope.
2. **First-swipe gut check** (no engineering): on paper or in Figma, mock up what the home feed looks like with 10 candidates the Instagram audience would recognize. Show the mock to 5-10 people. If their reaction is "why would I open this twice," rethink. If it's "oh, show me more," proceed.

Both validations should happen in the first two weeks. They're cheap and they'll save us 100+ hours of wasted build if the premise is wrong.

Part 7: What's explicitly out of scope for Milestone 1

- User accounts and login (beyond magic-link for staffers and admin password)
- Commenting, voting, or any social interaction
- Push notifications (email only)

- Native iOS or Android apps (that's Milestone 1B)
- Community content submissions (links and articles from users)
- AI drafting assistant, fallacy detector, or any AI conversation tools
- Leaderboards, badges, or gamification
- Candidate-to-candidate comparison pages
- The "See the Other Side" mechanic
- Any analytics dashboard for candidates beyond basic view counts (if even that)
- SMS or other delivery channels
- Monetization beyond donation referral codes